Seeing that the odds had turned against Scotland, David's new regent arranged to get him and his child wife, Joan, out of Scotland and into France, where Philip VI agreed to help him regain Scotland in return for David's homage to the French throne. Meanwhile, back in Scotland, Balliol repaid Edward III for his aid by handing over half of Scotland to the direct control of the English crown.[5]

But the war between England and Scotland had only been the prequel to a much longer and more complicated war between England and France.

War between England and France was nothing new. The two countries had never been friends, and their relationship had grown knottier when Henry II, heir to French lands by way of his father, had become the first king of England to owe homage to the French throne as Count of Anjou. The complicated interactions of the two monarchs, one of which was also the liege man of the other, had grown even thornier when Eleanor of Aquitaine had taken her family lands with her into the bed of the king of England, away from the king of France.

But the new war was slightly different. On October 19, 1337, Edward III dispatched a letter to his French counterpart. "Edward, by the grace of God King of England Ireland," it began, "to Philip of Valois . . ."

> We are heir to the realm and crown of France by a much closer degree of kingship than yourself, who have entered into possession of our heritage and are holding and desiring to hold it by force. . . . Wherefore we give you notice that we shall claim and conquer our heritage of France . . . since we consider you as our enemy and adversary.[6]

"This letter," Philip VI retorted, "does not require an answer." And with that dismissal of Edward's claim, the Hundred Years' War began.

The name, describing a whole series of campaigns that took place between 1337 and 1453, is a much later invention. Edward's first campaign—into the northern territory of Gascony—did not even begin until late in 1338, and the first major battle between the French and the English did not take place until June 24, 1340, when the English fleet destroyed the French navy at the Battle of Sluys. Long periods of peace intervened between years of intense fighting. And contemporary chroniclers such as Froissart see nothing particularly unusual in yet more war between France and England.[7]

But the hundred-plus years during which France and England fought are characterized by a deeper conflict than mere territorial battles: "The King of England," says Jean Froissart, "had long wished for an opportunity to assert his right to the crown of France." When Philip V had resurrected the old Salic